WEEK 08 / GAMING'S IMPACT ON PEOPLE AND SOCIETY

Gaming and Education

The intersection of education and gaming.

This week, we explore the intersection of education and gaming, discussing how games can be used as educational tools and the impact of edutainment on learning experiences.

---

26 RESOURCES / 1 TOPIC

TOPIC 01

Games and Learning

REQUIRED

Games and Education Scholar James Paul Gee on Video Games, Learning, and Literacy

YOUTUBE | ~6 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LNfPdaKYOPI&ab_channel=ConnectedLearningAlliance

James Paul Gee, a scholar in games and education, discusses how video games are fundamentally sets of problems that teach players to solve them in order to win. He highlights that the "design and learning" of games are often more trusted for assessment than traditional school methods, because games integrate assessment directly into the learning process.

Video games, from Civilization (history problems) to Halo (fantasy fighting), are essentially complex sets of problems that players must solve to succeed.
Unlike traditional schooling where testing is often separate and external, games inherently assess a player's mastery through gameplay, eliminating the need for separate tests.
- Gee advocates for "situated and embodied learning," where knowledge is used as a tool for problem-solving in specific contexts, allowing individuals to "do stuff" rather than just knowing inert facts.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

REQUIRED

How video games can level up the way you learn

TED TALK | ~13 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CkFnqGHZ5tA&pp=0gcJCdgAo7VqN5tD

Kris Alexander, a professor of video game design, argues that the principles of video games can significantly enhance traditional education and online instruction. Drawing on his personal experience of playing Zelda: The Minish Cap during lectures to combat cognitive overload, he demonstrates how video games' blend of audio, text, video, and interactivity can intensify focus and motivation. He emphasizes that effective instruction merges theory and practice through games, and highlights the potential of platforms like Twitch for online learning due to their ability to engage motivated learners. Alexander suggests that education needs clearer

objectives, much like video games, to better connect students' passions to their future careers.
- Kris Alexander found that playing Zelda: The Minish Cap during university lectures helped him pay attention because he is an oral learner, and the teacher's voice matching excessive text on slides caused "cognitive overload".
Video games, by design, are a complex blend of audio, text, video, and interactivity that can intensify focus and provide motivation, which students desperately need in the classroom.
Twitch, an online streaming platform primarily known for gaming, had an average of 2.78 million concurrent viewers in 2021 and is also used for learning skills like painting, playing piano, coding, and cooking.
- A 2022 study suggests that playing video games is associated with heightened cognition, faster reaction times, improved working memory, and modifications to cortical networks involved in playing.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

REQUIRED

How AI Immersive Learning Reshapes Education and Work

TED TALK | ~12 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Cj7DUKX8P3I&ab_channel=TEDxTalks

Patrick Lynch discusses the transformative potential of AI immersive learning, highlighting its roots in ancient storytelling and its relevance for preparing for a future with human-AI collaboration. He emphasizes that job security will increasingly depend on the ability to apply creative thinking with AI.

Immersive storytelling is an "ancient learning technique" affirmed by archaeological findings, where knowledge was passed down through visual means and direct engagement. This contrasts with traditional "sage on the stage" lectures.
Modern immersive experiences, such as interactive escape rooms and live-action role-play (LARP), allow executives and students to become "crew members" or "ship captains" to collaborate, solve problems, and build creative solutions, especially when working with generative AI as teammates or coaches.
- The future of AI immersive learning involves a blurring of digital and physical realities through technologies like AR and VR, enabling experiences like virtual oil rig firefighting or customer service training from home, accessible through wearables.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.
LO 5: Students will gain insights into how technologies like artificial intelligence, virtual reality, and online connectivity shape gaming experiences.

REQUIRED

Leveraging Gaming for Education

BLOG POST | ~8 MIN

https://gameplan.com/news/leveraging-gaming-for-education

This article argues that gaming, once seen as a distraction, is now recognized as a powerful educational tool that boosts student engagement and learning outcomes. It highlights how video games serve as a bridge between traditional content and students' digital-native interests, offering immediate feedback and adaptability for individualized learning.

Research indicates that using technology in the classroom can lead to significant increases in student motivation to learn (51%), application of knowledge (30%), and ownership of learning (23%). Gaming can also improve attention, focus, and concentration.
Gaming can be integrated into curricula in two main ways: co-curricular, through game-based learning platforms like Minecraft Education (for math, chemistry, media production) or esports (for cybersecurity, game

design, media production, critical thinking, collaboration); and extracurricular, as after-school programs or clubs to build soft skills like communication and leadership.
- Digital games are particularly useful in Special Education, showing benefits for children with dyslexia (improved reading), Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD) (reduced inappropriate behavior, enhanced play and social engagement), and ADHD (improved impulse control and attention). They also help students with physical, sensory, and visual impairments.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

REQUIRED

Find Fun: How to recognize video games that engage kids of all ages in learning

ARTICLE | ~3 MIN

https://www.gse.harvard.edu/ideas/usable-knowledge/21/06/find-fun

This Harvard Graduate School of Education article features insights from Louisa Rosenheck, a researcher at MIT's Education Arcade Lab, on what makes a truly effective learning game. She argues that good learning games are motivating because humans inherently enjoy learning and getting better at things, contrasting this with "gamification" which superficially adds game-like elements without fostering deep engagement.

Good learning games are open-ended, exploratory, allow learners agency or choice, spark curiosity, and provide "hard fun"-an appropriate level of challenge that is engaging and satisfying.
They focus on deeper concepts, exploration, and experimentation, providing feedback to help players understand systems and connect with real-world problems, rather than just drilling facts.
- Adults can support game-based learning by talking to kids about their play, emphasizing skills like persistence and working through frustration, recognizing social connections through games, and allowing kids to explore independently rather than providing direct instruction.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

REQUIRED

What Makes Great Learning Games?

YOUTUBE | ~16 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6uXUyBEAWR0&ab_channel=FilamentGames

Dan Norton of Filament Games discusses his company's approach to designing effective learning games, stemming from over a decade of experience. He outlines critical initial steps and three core strategies for translating learning objectives into engaging gameplay.

The first crucial steps are to clearly define learning objectives and then establish assessments to measure the intended impact, ensuring that the game effectively teaches what it aims to and that success can be objectively determined.
Filament Games uses three core strategies to integrate learning into mechanics: Identity (asking players to step into a role, like a scientist, to see the world from a new perspective or embody a professional practice); Verbs (creating digital actions or metaphors for doing things, like breeding plants using Punnett squares, to provide practice on specific skills); and Systems (designing rules that govern interactions in a complex world, like a plant's anatomy, to teach systems thinking and how parts work together).
- A key warning is to avoid making learning content feel like an "unfortunate tax" that needs to be "concealed" by the game; instead, the learning objective itself should be an exciting and interesting problem with a clear purpose and context for the learner's life.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine,

education, and social engagement.

REQUIRED

Learning to Game the (School) System | Edutainment Games and Educational Theory

YOUTUBE | ~54 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_BpAAps-OrU&ab_channel=ArchivistShepard

This video provides a comprehensive examination of edutainment games, drawing on personal childhood experiences and educational theory to analyze their potential as both video games and educational tools. It explores how these games leverage interactivity, motivation, narrative, characters, aesthetics, and sound design to engage learners.

Edutainment games have a two-fold goal for players: learning how to play the game (mechanics) and learning how to win by demonstrating understanding of educational material. Gameplay and learning are intrinsically linked, making the process more engaging and accessible.
Games motivate players through various features, including extrinsic rewards (points, in-game items, story progression) and intrinsic rewards (power-ups, abilities). Narrative provides contextual information, connecting game elements and increasing player absorption and motivation.
- These games excel at a one-student-to-one-teacher concept, offering individualized learning through features like adjustable difficulty (scaffolding), graceful failure (lowered consequences for risk-taking), and forced mastery of concepts to progress, helping bridge achievement gaps and build solid foundations.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

REQUIRED

13 (Secretly) Educational Video Games That Kids Will Actually Like

ARTICLE | ~11 MIN

https://www.cnet.com/tech/gaming/13-secretly-educational-video-games-that-kids-will-actually-like/

This CNET article highlights video games that are both entertaining and educational, demonstrating how developers subtly integrate learning into gameplay. It emphasizes that learning is most effective when it's fun. The article cites an ongoing study suggesting that children who play video games daily exhibit improved cognitive skills compared to those who do not. It then provides examples of popular games and the skills they teach.

Minecraft teaches creativity, problem-solving, collaboration, reading, and math by engaging players in world-building, resource gathering, and tool crafting. Parents have observed their children reading about biomes and calculating rations to improve in the game.
The Oregon Trail educates players on historical events, critical thinking, and problem-solving through a survival simulation where players manage resources and make long-term decisions to overcome challenges like illness and highway bandits.
- Other games mentioned include Wordscapes (vocabulary, logic), The Little Big Planet series (logic, spatial orientation, design, problem-solving), Portal series (logic, problem-solving, physics, math, science, spatial skills), Kerbal Space Program (physics, solar system, mathematics, aerospace engineering), Eloh (trigonometry, angles, critical thinking), Zoombinis (logic, patterns, data analysis, problem-solving), Where on Google Earth is Carmen Sandiego? (geography, historical events), Nancy Drew Interactive Mysteries (historical events, figures, critical thinking, foreign cultures, languages, problem-solving), Democracy series (government functions, compromise, cause and effect, strategy, conflict resolution), National Geographic Challenge (historical figures, events, geography), and World Rescue (geography, conservation, global problems, healthy living, activism). I'm not sure all of these are still available or the links may have changed,

but there’s a lot of good stuff here still.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

REQUIRED

The Effective Use of Game-Based Learning in Education | Andre Thomas | TEDxTAMU

TED TALK | ~18 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-X1m7tf9cRQ&ab_channel=TEDxTalks

Andre Thomas argues that education should return to its roots of "play" and "doing," contrasting the effectiveness of game-based learning with traditional passive learning methods like lectures. He emphasizes that real-world mastery is often 100%, unlike the 90% pass rates often accepted in academia.

Learning through "doing" (like riding a bike) is inherently more effective than learning by reading, watching, or listening. Games provide this active, hands-on engagement.
Games are a powerful medium that can teach complex information, such as Pokemon's dual-type abilities (over 27 million active users), which are remembered years later, in contrast to the often-forgotten Periodic Table of Elements.
- Games promote mastery by requiring 100% completion to advance to the next level, and they normalize failure as a fun, motivating part of the learning process, unlike the stigmatized failure in schools. Thomas showcases Variant Limits, a calculus game that significantly improved student mastery and grades.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Visuo-spatial attention and reading abilities: an action game prototype for dyslexic children

ACADEMIC PAPER

https://air.unimi.it/retrieve/dfa8b993-8ee2-748b-e053-3a05fe0a3a96/REM2015.pdf

This paper details the MADRIGALE project, which aims to design and develop an action game prototype specifically for dyslexic children to improve reading skills. The research suggests that action video games, even those not directly related to phonological or orthographic training, can significantly intervene on visuo-spatial attention and drastically improve reading abilities.

The prototype utilizes DFONT 2.0 (Dyslexic Font), which has specific graphical properties like letters in "cages," increased blank character width, and distinct shapes for commonly mistaken letters (e.g., 'b' and 'd') to facilitate reading for dyslexics.
Key pedagogical design elements include skill levels with increasing difficulty (based on number/type of letters, word length, and symbol layout) to improve user involvement and self-esteem, and reinforcement techniques like colored boxes, high-contrast combinations, and intonation to help users distinguish letters and improve performance.
- A survey of 50 primary school teachers experienced with dyslexic students found the game suitable for ages 6-7, with 96% finding its content and interaction effective. 100% of teachers responded positively to the idea of introducing a level editor to customize scenarios and word lists, indicating a strong desire for adaptability in the game's complexity and difficulty.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

EXPLORE FURTHER

More Than Just Fun and Games: The Longitudinal Relationships Between Strategic Video Games, Self-Reported Problem Solving Skills, and Academic Grades

ARTICLE | ~80 MIN

https://maine.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01MAINE_INST/1oa9cn5/cdi_proquest_miscellaneous_1429629833

This empirical research study investigates the longitudinal relationship between strategic video game play, self-reported problem-solving skills, and academic grades among adolescents over the four years of high school. It addresses the gap in research on positive outcomes of video game play, contrasting with prior focus on negative effects like addiction and aggression.
- The study found that more strategic video game play (role-playing and strategy games) predicted higher self-reported problem-solving skills over time compared to less strategic or fast-paced video game play. Strategic games, like Splinter Cell or World of Warcraft, encourage players to gather information, weigh options, and formulate strategies before acting, which enhances problem-solving skills.
Results supported an indirect association between strategic video game play and academic grades: strategic video game play predicted higher self-reported problem-solving skills, which, in turn, predicted higher academic grades. Fast-paced games (fighting, action, racing) did not show this positive link.
The research specifically supported a cognitive training effect (playing strategic video games leads to an increase in problem-solving skills), but did not find support for a selection effect (individuals with better problem-solving skills are more likely to play strategic games); in fact, higher problem-solving skills predicted less strategic video game play in a later grade, possibly due to self-selection into academic activities.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Interactive Video Games in Physical Education

ARTICLE

https://eric.ed.gov/?id=EJ795570

“As the obesity epidemic in the United States spreads among children and teenagers, due in part to sedentary lifestyles, some physical education programs are using interactive video games to keep students engaged in physical activity. These innovative games make physical activity fun and challenging for both high- and low-skilled students. Although little empirical data are available on these games, countless newspaper and magazine articles describe how fun and physically engaging they are. In addition to being entertaining, these games measure heart rate, power, and reaction time; estimate caloric expenditure; search for movement deficits; and require students to aim, strike, and move in ways they never have before. This article examines five products--Dance Dance Revolution, Cybex Trazer, Eyetoy, Cateye Gamebike, and Sportwall--and gives practical strategies for implementing them in a physical education setting. Ideas for obtaining grant money, donations, and funds are also explored.”

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

EXPLORE FURTHER

50 Educational Video Games That Homeschoolers Love

ARTICLE

https://www.oedb.org/ilibrarian/50-educational-video-games-that-homeschoolers-love/

This article from OEDB.org lists a variety of educational video games favored by homeschoolers, categorizing them by gaming platform (Wii, Xbox, PlayStation), handheld devices, computer, online, and iPad. It challenges

the common negative perception of video games by highlighting their potential to help students learn new things, develop problem-solving skills, and foster creativity in an enjoyable format.

Video games can be effective educational tools for students of all ages, from kindergarten to high school, and are already being adopted by many schools and homeschoolers.
Examples across platforms include My Word Coach (verbal communication), National Geographic Challenge (geographic knowledge), SimCity (city planning, environmental impact, natural disasters), Minecraft (creativity, problem-solving), and Rocket Math (math missions).
- The games listed aim to make learning fun, engaging students in subjects like language skills, science, history, and math through interactive experiences.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Video Games in Education

YOUTUBE | ~7 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=c5AN0JDmQY4&ab_channel=Sprouts

This video explores the role of video games in education, outlining three dimensions of game design, four potential learning benefits, and five specific video games that offer powerful learning experiences. It posits that play, even in video games, is a high form of research.

Games typically range from simple to complex, single-player to multiplayer, and collaborative to competitive; complex multiplayer games are often most effective for learning.
Four potential benefits of video games in education include increasing cognitive abilities (mental rotation, logic, math, spatial relations), boosting motivation (through feedback loops and fostering a growth mindset), providing emotional benefits (improving mood, managing stress), and strengthening social skills (learning trust, communication, leadership, and pro-social behaviors).
- Examples of games that deliver powerful learning experiences include Remission (teaches sick children about cancer treatment), Minecraft (creativity, collaboration, problem-solving, STEM), Democracy (politics, economics), Brain Quake (math), and the Harvard Root Beer Game (business simulation, teamwork).

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Jim Gee Principles on Gaming

YOUTUBE | ~24 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4aQAgAjTozk&ab_channel=ChrisThorn

James Paul Gee outlines 13 principles that good video games employ to foster effective learning, problem-solving, and deep understanding, suggesting these principles can be applied to educational design. He categorizes these principles into three areas: empowered learners, problem-based learning, and deep understanding.

Empowered Learners: Games empower learners through the Agent/Co-Design principle (players influence the game and feel like agents), Customization principle (allowing different play styles and safe experimentation), Identity principle (taking on roles with clear goals, like a scientist or adventurer), and Manipulation principle (fine control over the game world, deeply engaging body and mind with learning tools).
Problem-Based Learning: Games excel at problem-solving via the Sequencing Problems principle (levels teaching progressively harder solutions), Pleasantly Frustrating principle (challenging but achievable problems leading to "flow"), Cycle of Expertise principle (practicing routine knowledge, then challenging it with "boss

battles" to ratchet up mastery), Just-in-Time/On-Demand Information principle (giving information when needed), Fish Tank principle (simplifying complex systems in early levels, gradually adding complexity), Sandboxes principle (safe spaces for exploration and risk-taking without immediate judgment), and Skills Under Strategies principle (practicing basic skills within meaningful problem-solving contexts).
- Deep Understanding: Games create deep understanding through System Thinking principle (building mental models of complex interacting rules, fostering scientific reasoning) and Situated Meaning principle (associating words/symbols with images, actions, goals, and experiences rather than just definitions).

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Classroom Game Design: Paul Andersen at TEDxBozeman

TED TALK | ~11 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4qlYGX0H6Ec&ab_channel=TEDxTalks

Paul Andersen, a science teacher, describes his journey of reinventing his classroom as a video game, inspired by his childhood experiences with gaming. He aims to apply the compelling elements of gaming to create an active, student-centered learning environment, contrasting it with traditional passive teacher-centered methods.

Andersen learned key lessons from video games that he applies to his classroom: school should be fun, failure is okay (it's part of the learning process), and the importance of leveling (students moving at their own pace and becoming more powerful as they learn).
His "Biohazard 5" class incorporates elements like a narrative, 150 podcasts for lectures, special activities for real-world application, inquiry labs, a mastery system where students can retake quizzes repeatedly until they succeed, a leveling system with experience points, and a leaderboard.
- He acknowledges challenges he faced, such as students needing more scaffolding when driving their own learning, struggles with reading when forced to read independently, and the importance of incorporating social learning elements because kids come to school to be social.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

EXPLORE FURTHER

The Power of Gamification in Education | Scott Hebert | TEDxUAlberta

TED TALK | ~19 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mOssYTimQwM&ab_channel=TEDxTalks

Scott Hebert addresses the "engagement crisis" in education, arguing that the system is static and fails to meet students' needs for dynamism, choice, and passion. He advocates for gamification as a core change, not just a superficial one, to make learning relevant and engaging.

Students report school is boring, repetitive, and lacks choice, with little reason to care about the content. Hebert asserts that educators need to humanize work and make students believe their efforts have purpose.
Gamification, applying game design principles to non-game contexts like school, can address this crisis. He references the creativity and choice inherent in games like Minecraft where players are self-motivated to build and explore for hours.
- He emphasizes that play is not the antithesis of learning; animals play to learn survival skills, and humans gain skills like reaction speed. Gamification allows for safe failure, encouraging risk-taking and perseverance without negative consequences like lower grades, empowering students and fostering future innovators.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Gamification in Higher Education | Christopher See | TEDxCUHK

TED TALK | ~17 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=d8s3kZz1yQ4&ab_channel=TEDxTalks

Christopher See discusses the application of gamification and game-based learning, particularly in higher education and medical training. He argues for a "fundamental underlying structural overlap" between what one does in a game and what one should do in education, emphasizing the mechanics of games over their specific content.

See uses the example of an escape room to illustrate how game structures can be leveraged for learning, as they involve mental puzzles, recalling information, pattern recognition, communication, and working under pressure-skills similar to exams and studying.
His approach involves using "core content" (like cardiovascular anatomy, physiology, and pharmacology) rather than "junk data" within game structures, such as puzzles that require students to identify drug classes by their endings.
- He challenges common myths about game-based learning: it is not about making learning "easier" or inherently "fun," but rather about making students do the hard work themselves by creating engaging challenges that stimulate discussion and deeper thinking.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Your brain on video games | Daphne Bavelier

TED TALK | ~18 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FktsFcooIG8&ab_channel=TED

Daphne Bavelier, a brain scientist, shares her research on the positive effects of action-packed shooter video games on the brain, challenging common negative perceptions about screen time. She emphasizes leveraging the power of pervasive video gaming for education and rehabilitation.

Action video games can significantly improve vision, enhancing the ability to resolve small details in clutter and distinguish different levels of gray, leading to vision "better than normal" players. This research is being leveraged to develop games for patients with low vision.
Playing action games does not lead to attention problems; rather, it improves attention, allowing faster resolution of cognitive conflicts (like the Stroop effect) and enhancing the ability to track multiple objects simultaneously. Brain imaging reveals that networks controlling attention (parietal cortex, frontal lobe, anterior cingulate) become more efficient in action game players.
- Bavelier clarifies that not all media are created equal: action games have distinct positive effects on cognition and perception, contrasting sharply with high multimedia-tasking, which negatively impacts multitasking skills. She likens the beneficial "ingredients" in action games to those in wine (in reasonable doses), stating that these ingredients are powerful for brain plasticity, learning, and attention, and research aims to extract them for better educational and rehabilitation games.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.
LO 4: Students will be able to discuss ethical concerns surrounding gaming, including issues related to violence, addiction, monetization practices, labor concerns, and virtual identities.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Common Sense Media

WEBSITE

https://www.commonsensemedia.org/

“Since 2003, Common Sense has been the leading independent source for media recommendations and advice for families.” Includes video games, movies, TV shows, podcasts, and other media.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.
LO 4: Students will be able to discuss ethical concerns surrounding gaming, including issues related to violence, addiction, monetization practices, labor concerns, and virtual identities.
LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Ubisoft's Echoes of History Podcast

PODCAST

https://open.spotify.com/show/32D0s4zdgKVDplzPf8GZBO

Official podcast description: “Dive into the real-life history that inspires the locations, characters, and storylines of the legendary world of Assassin’s Creed. ‘Echoes of History’ is the official Assassin's Creed history podcast. We’ll head down the narrow side streets of Medici-ruled Florence, cross sand dunes in the shadow of ancient pyramids, climb the rigging of 18th century brigs sailing across the Caribbean and meet the most powerful warlords in Feudal Japan - all before hearing from the developers themselves to understand how and why these moments are recreated in the acclaimed historical game series. Every week, join historian Matt Lewis, and regular contributor Holly Nielsen, as they speak to historical experts about the secrets of the past and uncover how these stories influence Assassin’s Creed.”

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Pastplay: Teaching and Learning History with Technology

BOOK

https://muse.jhu.edu/book/29517

Book description: “In the field of history, the Web and other technologies have become important tools in research and teaching of the past. Yet the use of these tools is limited-many historians and history educators have resisted adopting them because they fail to see how digital tools supplement and even improve upon conventional tools (such as books). In Pastplay, a collection of essays by leading history and humanities researchers and teachers, editor Kevin Kee works to address these concerns head-on. How should we use technology? Playfully, Kee contends. Why? Because doing so helps us think about the past in new ways; through the act of creating technologies, our understanding of the past is re-imagined and developed. From the insights of numerous scholars and teachers, Pastplay argues that we should play with technology in history because doing so enables us to see the past in new ways by helping us understand how history is created; honoring the roots of research, teaching, and technology development; requiring us to model our thoughts; and then allowing us to build our own understanding.”
This book is free to read and download online.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Create Educational Games with TinyTap

YOUTUBE | ~17 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5GkZZ97_CR8&ab_channel=TechnologyforTeachersandStudents

This video demonstrates how to create educational games using TinyTap, a tool accessible via its website. It covers searching for existing games, but emphasizes the ability for users to create their own custom learning experiences.

TinyTap provides various creation packs (themes, shapes, frames) and tools for uploading images, searching for clip art/animations, and adding text to design game screens or "levels".
Users can build different interactive activity types, including "Ask a Question" (recording questions and outlining correct answers), "Puzzle" (tracing shapes to create puzzle pieces), "Sound Board" (linking sounds to objects), and "Talk or Type" (tracing an area for a text input with correct answers).
- Once created, games can be published publicly with a name, description, category, language, and age range, generating a shareable URL or embed code for easy access by others, even without a TinyTap account.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Dangerous Games: Roblox and the Metaverse Exposed (Documentary Trailer)

YOUTUBE | ~2 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=qkQ4y_3VKCQ

A trailer for a documentary only available in Canada right now, apparently… Three young gamers expose the dark side of the metaverse-where predators, extremists, and criminals thrive unchecked. The dangers aren't just virtual.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 4: Students will be able to discuss ethical concerns surrounding gaming, including issues related to violence, addiction, monetization practices, labor concerns, and virtual identities.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Predators on Roblox? Chris Hansen Reveals the Truth Parents Need to Hear

YOUTUBE | ~65 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=HxvXdyxV3So

In a panel discussion hosted by Chris Hansen, victim-turned advocate and YouTuber "Schlep", attorney Steve Vanderporten and Marion County, Florida Sheriff's Office Detective Henrik Osthed expose rampant child exploitation and predator grooming on the immensely popular gaming platform Roblox. The participants reveal how predators manipulate vulnerable youth using the platform's in-game currency and off-platform applications like Discord, while corporate leadership allegedly prioritizes user engagement and financial gain over child safety. Despite mounting legal battles and whistleblower efforts, Roblox continues to neglect adequate moderation, leading to systemic danger that demands heightened parental vigilance and stronger accountability measures.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.

LO 4: Students will be able to discuss ethical concerns surrounding gaming, including issues related to violence, addiction, monetization practices, labor concerns, and virtual identities.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Press Play -- Gaming, Simulation & Achievement in the Classroom: Jonathon Best at TEDxDenverTeachers

TED TALK | ~17 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lKpo5SeZWns&ab_channel=TEDxTalks

Jonathon Best, an educator, proposes integrating simulation and gaming into the classroom to drive motivation and performance. He suggests that since many students already live in "highly simulated" worlds outside of school, denying this presence in the classroom can alienate them.

Simulation-based learning aims to allow students to connect to complex material through imagined or simulated experiences. Examples include creating classroom avatars to dismiss negative baggage and experience risk differently (like Mario falling into a fire pit, you just restart).
Other forms of simulation-based learning include Discovery-based instruction, thematically designing units around quests or challenges (e.g., defeating an evil boss), and implementing in-class achievement systems (like Xbox/PlayStation achievements) to celebrate successes collectively.
- Best emphasizes a "vernacular shift" (e.g., an exit ticket becomes a "boss battle") and daily tracking of student/avatar progress to provide ownership and engagement. He believes this approach can make education more equitable and liberating by meeting students where they are.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.